

Business Communication Reference Handbook

Professional email

A useful subject line tells the reader what the message is about. The first paragraph should make the purpose clear rather than spending several sentences on background.

Requests should be specific. 'Please send the revised file by Thursday afternoon' is easier to act on than 'please update me soon'.

Tone should match the relationship and situation. Direct language can still be polite. Long greetings and excessive formality often make routine work emails harder to scan.

Project updates

A short update usually needs context, completed work, current work, blockers, and next steps. The exact order can change, but the reader should quickly see whether anything needs attention.

A blocker should name what is blocked and what is needed. 'Waiting on API access from the client' is more useful than 'blocked'.

Don't turn an update into a diary of every action taken. Include details that change decisions or next steps.

Meeting notes

Useful notes capture decisions, owners, deadlines, and open questions. A transcript records everything said, but notes should select what matters after the meeting.

Action items should be written so another person can understand the task without replaying the meeting.

Where a decision is tentative, the notes should say so instead of presenting it as final.